

Blender Philosophies & RH Families

Module purpose · from origin stereotypes to predictive analysis

- Explain why blender philosophy matters more than country of origin.
- Identify construction and combustion signals across cigar styles.
- Classify cigars into RH Families and estimate peak-flavour RH.
- Predict behaviour before smoking and validate through controlled diagnostics.



The professional objective: move from reactive smoking to predictive analysis.



Module 4 Learning Map

What this module covers

- Why blenders matter more than origin
- RH Families as behavioural systems
- Family A: clarity-driven / aromatic
- Family B: balanced boutique
- Family C: power / ligero-heavy
- Hybrid and edge-case cigars
- Rapid classification, professional scenarios and examination alignment



Why Blenders Matter More Than Origin

Country is context; construction determines behaviour

- Country can suggest climate, soil, seed availability and broad flavour traditions.
- It does not by itself determine combustion temperature, moisture tolerance or peak smoking RH.
- Two cigars from the same country, factory or brand can behave differently when their construction philosophy differs.

4

CUBAN VS NEW WORLD PHILOSOPHY

DIFFERENT GOALS. DIFFERENT RH.

CUBAN PHILOSOPHY

Combustion clarity is the priority

Lower oil saturation

Lower RH activation

Sharper, drier burning style

Focus on linearity and finesse

VS

NEW WORLD PHILOSOPHY

Oil retention is the priority

Higher fermentation

Higher RH activation

Rounder, richer burning style

Focus on depth and complexity

60% RH is ideal for many Cubans.

62–63% RH is ideal for many Nicaraguans.

BOTH ARE CORRECT — WITHIN THEIR ARCHITECTURE.

Professional service asks how the cigar was engineered to combust.



The Myth of Country-Based Prediction

Avoid convenient but unreliable shortcuts

- “Nicaraguan = strong”, “Dominican = mild” and “Cuban = wetter” are incomplete generalisations.
- Origin-based assumptions can hide differences in priming, fermentation, wrapper structure and filler density.
- Professional classification begins with observable construction evidence, not nationality.

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The Blender as Combustion Architect

A cigar is an engineered moisture-response system

- The blender selects leaves, fermentation depth and rolling structure.
- Those decisions control how combustion progresses and how flavour is delivered.
- In practical terms, the blender designs a combustion system, a flavour-delivery system and a moisture-response system.



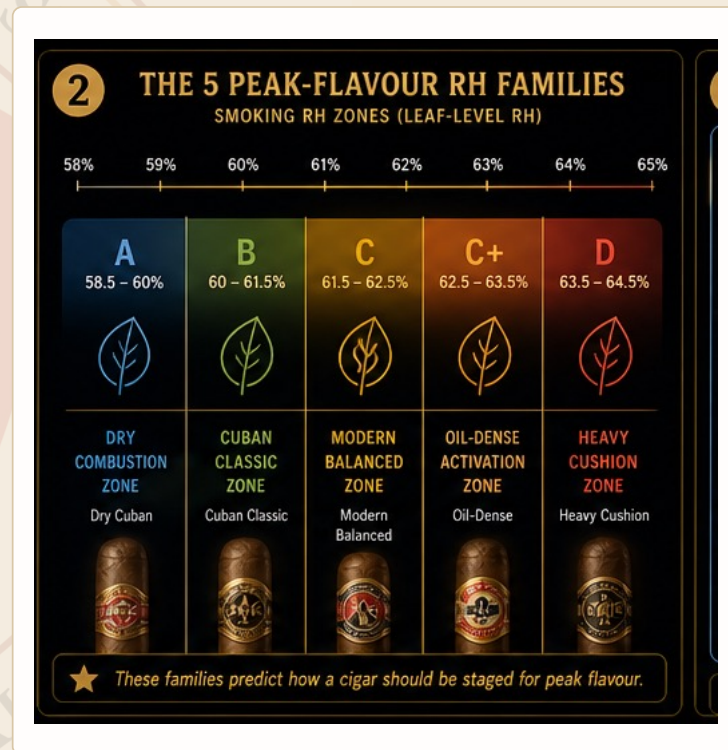
RH behaviour is designed into the cigar.



What Is an RH Family?

Behavioural classification, not geography

- An RH Family groups cigars with similar combustion behaviour, moisture tolerance and peak-flavour RH ranges.
- The family describes how the cigar responds to moisture during smoking.
- Classification therefore relies on cigar performance rather than country or marketing category.

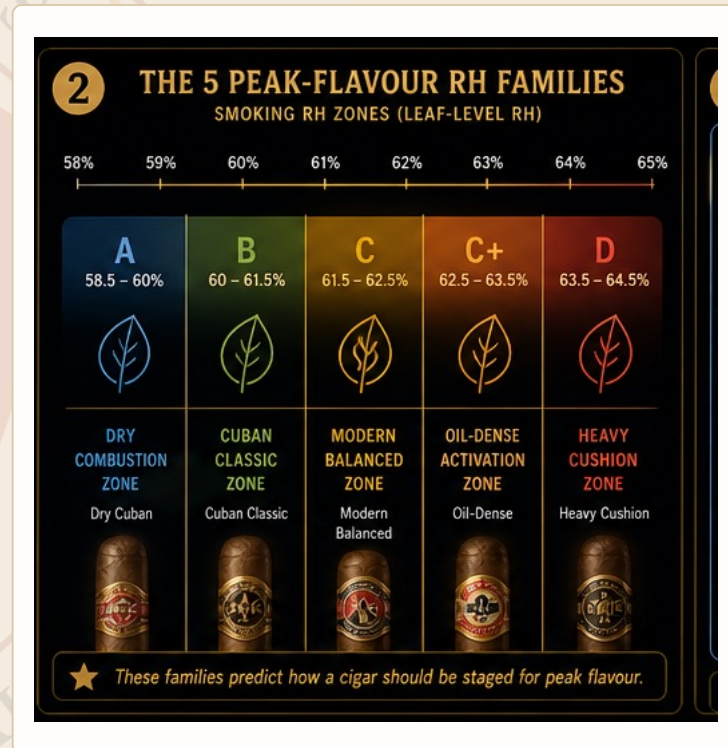


RH Families convert individual observations into a scalable professional system.

Why RH Families Matter

Prediction becomes faster and more consistent

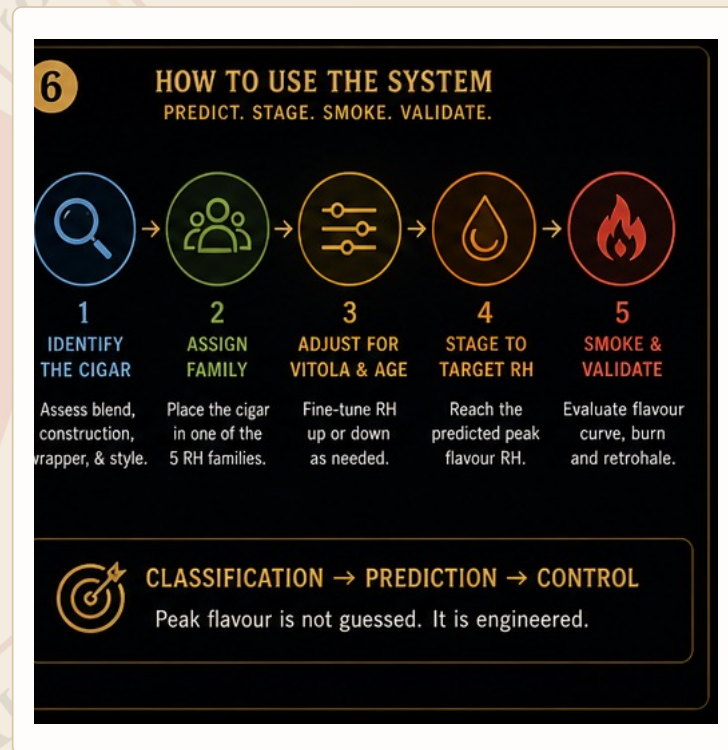
- Classify unfamiliar cigars more quickly.
- Estimate a useful starting RH range before smoking.
- Predict likely flavour behaviour and failure modes.
- Troubleshoot systematically instead of learning every cigar from zero.



Professional Perspective

What separates trained analysis from casual experience

- Examine the cigar before ignition.
- Assess construction, wrapper behaviour and density.
- Form a provisional prediction of how it will behave.
- Validate the prediction through controlled smoking diagnostics.



The goal is not certainty before smoking; it is a defensible prediction.

RH Family A Clarity-Driven / Aromatic

Typical Peak-Flavour RH: 59–61%

- Prioritises aroma clarity, flavour precision, evolution and refined combustion.
- Often rewards a slightly hotter, cleaner burn and careful moisture control.
- Emphasises nuance and transition over raw power.

3 FAMILY PROFILES AT A GLANCE				
A	B	C	C+	D
58.5 – 60%	60 – 61.5%	61.5 – 62.5%	62.5 – 63.5%	63.5 – 64.5%
DRY COMBUSTION ZONE	CUBAN CLASSIC ZONE	MODERN BALANCED ZONE	OIL-DENSE ACTIVATION ZONE	HEAVY CUSHION ZONE
Philosophy Sharp combustion, high aromatic clarity.	Philosophy Balance of sharpness and sweetness.	Philosophy Maximum aromatic lift without muting.	Philosophy Controlled softness to unlock oil-rich wrappers.	Philosophy High moisture buffer for thick, oil-saturated blends.
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⚠ Family D is rare and unstable. Not recommended for Cuban blends.				

Family A is highly sensitive to excess moisture.



Family A Construction Signals

Look for a structure built for aromatic expression

- Thinner wrappers and lower oil content.
- Moderate filler density.
- Cooler or longer fermentation profiles.
- Greater seco/viso emphasis.
- Construction designed for aromatic expression rather than combustion buffering.



Family A Combustion Behaviour

Why over-humidification quickly suppresses performance

- Excess moisture can suppress flavour clarity and dull smoke texture.
- Combustion efficiency can decline quickly above the intended range.
- At proper RH, flavours feel precise, transitions stay clean and sweetness becomes more visible.
- Above peak RH, complexity can collapse even when the cigar feels smooth.

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Family A Common Student Errors

Smoothness is not proof of correct RH

- Storing clarity-driven cigars too wet.
- Assuming “mild” means moisture-tolerant or forgiving.
- Confusing smoothness with correct combustion performance.
- Ignoring how quickly aromatic definition disappears above peak RH.

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These can be among the most RH-sensitive cigars in professional service.



RH Family B Balanced Boutique

Typical Peak-Flavour RH: 61–62%

- Designed for balance, texture, sweetness and controlled complexity.
- Balances aromatic clarity with body.
- Usually tolerates moderate moisture variation better than Family A.
- Often performs consistently across multiple environments.

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Versatile does not mean maintenance-free.



Family B Construction Signals

Equilibrium rather than extremes

- Medium wrapper thickness.
- Moderate oil presence.
- Balanced filler structures.
- Hybrid fermentation approaches.
- Construction seeks a stable compromise between clarity and body.



Family B Combustion Behaviour

Stable, predictable, but still RH-dependent

- Typically shows stable combustion and predictable progression.
- At proper RH, sweetness, body and aroma feel integrated.
- Outside the intended band, the cigar can lose flavour precision or combustion control.
- Precision still matters even in a tolerant family.

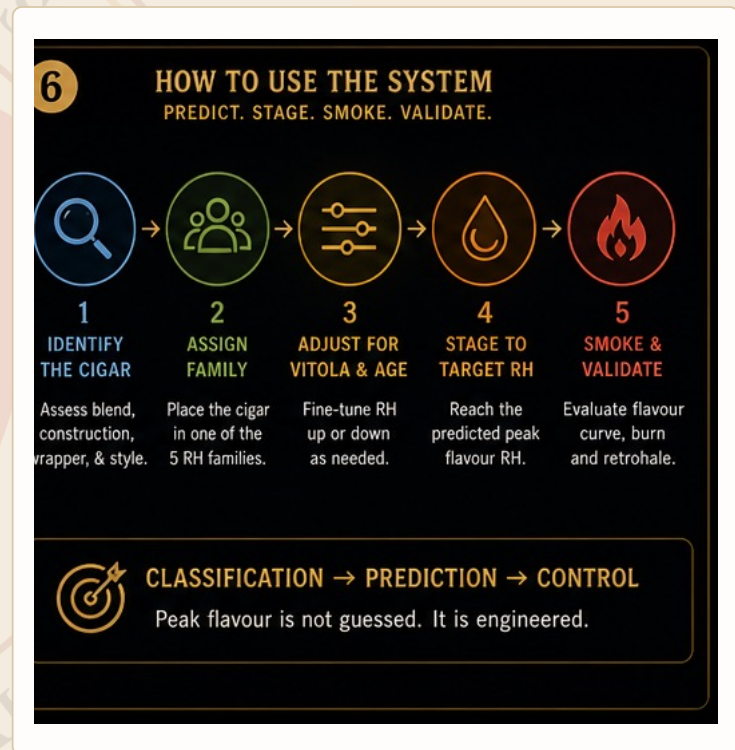
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Family B Professional Implications

Why this family works well in service environments

- Often suitable for training because behaviour is comparatively stable.
- Adaptable across lounge environments and consumer preferences.
- Less polarising for guests than more extreme constructions.
- Still requires deliberate RH management and validation.



RH Family C/C+/D Power Ligerio-Heavy

Typical Peak-Flavour RH: 63–65%

- Prioritises richness, strength, smoke density and mouthfeel.
- Often designed to combust more slowly and buffer stronger tobaccos.
- Moderately higher RH can help stabilise combustion and nicotine delivery.

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Powerful construction often needs moisture buffering, not dryness.



Family C/C+/D Construction Signals

Look for mass, oil and combustion resistance

- Heavy ligero use.
- Thick, oily wrappers.
- Dense rolling and higher thermal mass.
- Deeper or warmer fermentation styles.
- Construction engineered for power, texture and combustion buffering.



Family C/C+/D Combustion Behaviour

Why excessive dryness destabilises powerful cigars

- When too dry, combustion heat rises rapidly.
- Pepper sharpens, nicotine feels aggressive and flavour balance collapses.
- Moderately higher RH slows combustion and preserves integration.
- At proper RH, smoke remains dense but controlled and sweetness survives beneath the power.

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Family C/C+/D Common Misdiagnosis

Harshness is not the same as intentional strength

- Smokers may interpret harshness as strength or pepper as premium richness.
- Under-humidification can create an aggressive profile that was never intended by the blender.
- Diagnose combustion before judging the blend.

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Lower oil saturation

Lower RH activation

Sharper, drier burning style

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BOTH ARE CORRECT — WITHIN THEIR ARCHITECTURE.

Strength is a design attribute; harshness can be a preparation failure.

Hybrid & Edge-Case Cigars

Some cigars intentionally combine family behaviours

- Hybrids may broaden consumer appeal, create transitional styles or improve environmental versatility.
- They often require more careful staging, tighter RH control and more observational smoking.
- Do not force an ambiguous cigar into a family without evidence.

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How to Classify Hybrid Cigars

Prioritise physical evidence

- 1. Wrapper behaviour: thickness, oiliness and moisture response.
- 2. Filler density: mass, resistance and likely thermal behaviour.
- 3. Fermentation style: depth and expected combustion buffering.
- Marketing language, colour descriptors and country stereotypes are secondary evidence at best.

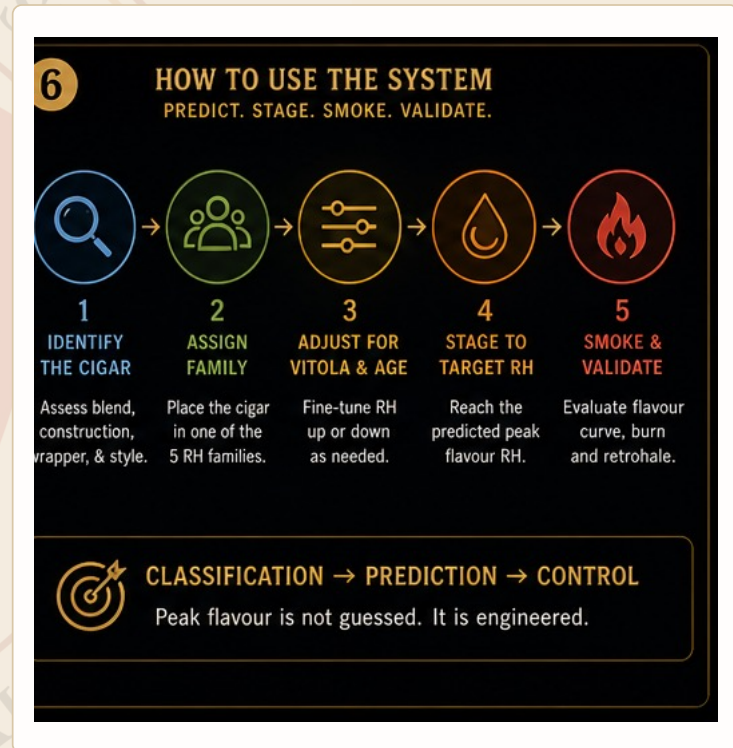


Classification should remain evidence-driven.

Rapid Professional Classification

A five-step field method

- STEP 1 - Assess wrapper thickness, oiliness and surface texture.
- STEP 2 - Estimate filler density, combustion resistance and fermentation depth.
- STEP 3 - Consider blender philosophy, intended smoking style and target consumer.
- STEP 4 - Assign a provisional RH Family.
- STEP 5 - Validate through smoking diagnostics.



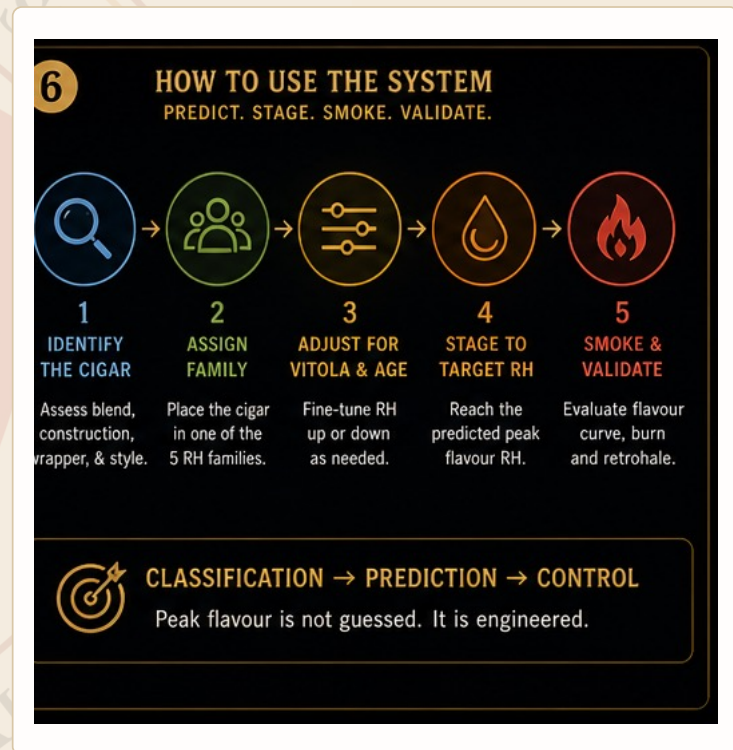
PREDICT → STAGE → SMOKE → VALIDATE



Scenario 1 – New Brand in a Lounge

How to prepare an unfamiliar cigar professionally

- Assess construction signals before placing it into the service environment.
- Assign a provisional RH Family.
- Stage conservatively around the predicted range.
- Validate with controlled smoking before standardising service conditions.

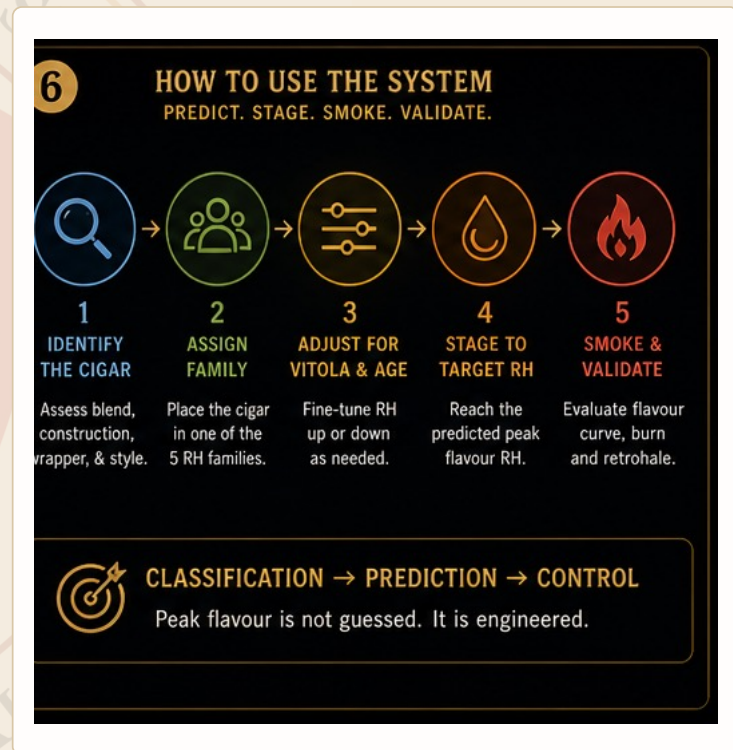


The first decision is a hypothesis; the smoking test validates it.

Scenario 2 – Customer Dislikes a Premium Cigar

Diagnose preparation before abandoning the brand

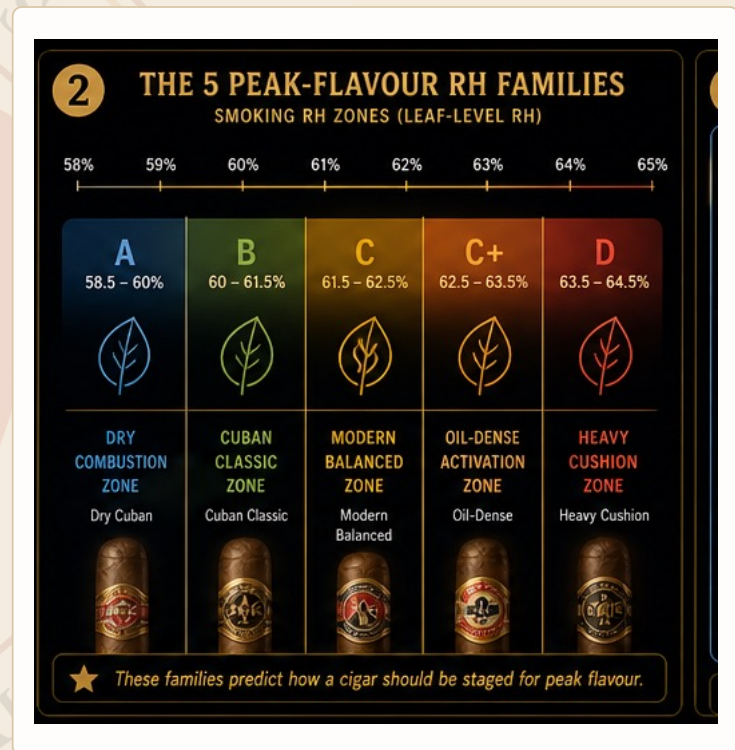
- Evaluate whether the cigar was staged in the wrong RH family range.
- Reassess preparation and serving conditions.
- Adjust humidity strategy before concluding the blend is unsuitable.
- This preserves customer trust, service quality and diagnostic accuracy.



Examination Alignment

What candidates must be able to demonstrate

- Classify cigars into RH Families.
- Justify classifications causally using construction and combustion evidence.
- Explain behavioural differences between families.
- Avoid origin-based assumptions and wrapper-colour shortcuts.



Common Examination Errors

What weak answers usually do

- Rely too heavily on country stereotypes.
- Confuse wrapper colour with combustion behaviour.
- Trust brand prestige over construction evidence.
- Assume stronger cigars always require lower RH.
- Describe preference instead of explaining causal behaviour.

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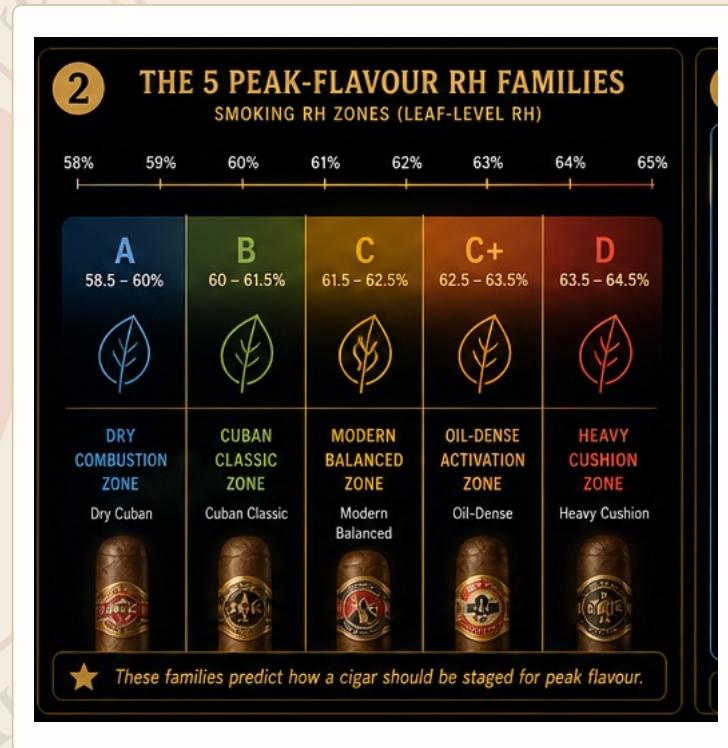
Professional analysis must be combustion-based, observational and evidence-driven.



Core Professional Principles

Five statements candidates should be able to defend

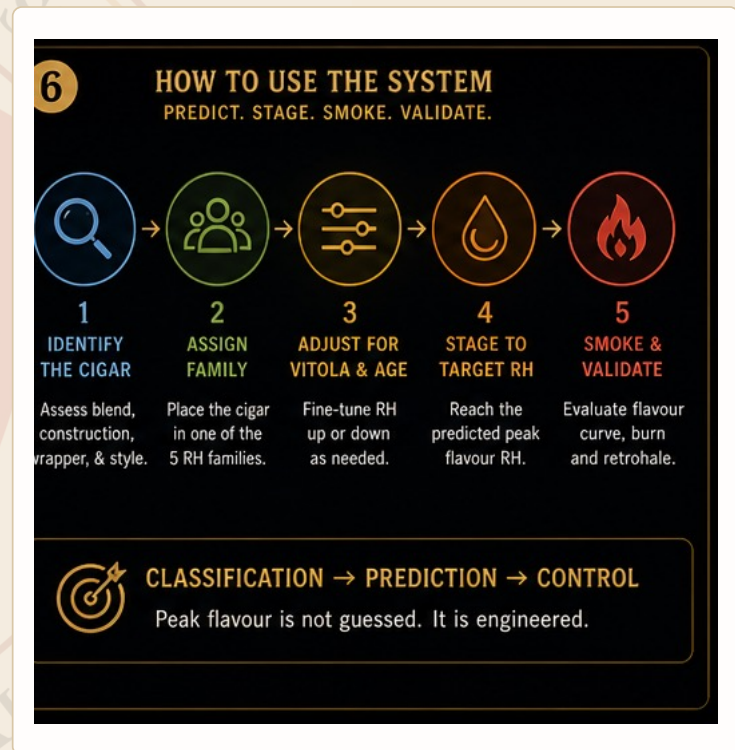
- Blender philosophy determines combustion behaviour.
- RH Families are behavioural systems, not geographic categories.
- Moisture tolerance is intentionally designed into a cigar.
- Misclassification causes many smoking failures.
- Predictive RH classification is a hallmark of professional expertise.



Module 4 Summary

From “smoke it and see” to predictive classification

- Cigars cluster into recognisable behavioural families.
- Those families reflect blender intent and construction.
- Peak-flavour RH can often be estimated before smoking.
- Professional cigar management becomes scalable through classification.
- The final smoking test validates, rather than creates the initial hypothesis.



“I understand how this cigar is likely to behave before ignition.”

